

Historical Data Methodology Note

Internet Accountability Compass

The Internet Accountability Compass tracks 12 indicators across four dimensions for 194 countries, covering the years 2020–2025. This note explains how scores were assembled for the historical editions (2020–2024), including data sources, transformations, and the treatment of years where data is unavailable or only partially available. All indicator scores are expressed on a 0–100 scale unless otherwise noted.

General Principles

Data primacy. Real, year-specific data is used wherever available. No historical value is inferred or estimated when a verified source exists for that year.

Gap-filling. Where a source does not publish annually, the most recent available value prior to the gap year is carried forward as a proxy. This is noted per indicator below. Proxy values are not distinguished from real values in the dataset itself, but the methodology is documented here.

NA. Cells are marked NA where no data exists and no reasonable proxy can be applied.

Total score threshold. A country receives a total index score only if data is present for at least 8 of the 12 indicators. Otherwise the cell reads “not enough data”.

Cardinal scores. Each cardinal score is the average of available indicators within that cardinal direction, even if only one of three is present.

Indicator-by-Indicator Methodology

Connectivity and Infrastructure

1. ICT Development Index (IDI)

Source: International Telecommunication Union (ITU)

Coverage: 2020–2022 (proxy); 2023–2025 (real data)

The ICT Development Index measures the level of ICT access, use, and skills in countries, combining 11 indicators including mobile subscriptions, internet users, and education levels. The ITU discontinued the IDI series between 2018 and 2022. For index years 2020–2022, the 2018 IDI edition is used as a proxy, min-max normalised to a 0–100 scale. Nine countries that lacked a 2018 IDI entry (ATG, COD, DOM, KNA, LCA, VCT, STP, TTO, TUR) are marked NA for those years. Real ITU IDI data resumes from 2023 onwards and is used directly for 2023, 2024, and 2025.

2. Network Readiness Index (NRI)

Source: Portulans Institute in collaboration with Oxford University

Coverage: 2021–2025 (real data); 2020 = NA

The NRI evaluates how prepared countries are to benefit from digital transformation, incorporating factors such as technology infrastructure, governance, people, and impact. Scores range from 0 to 100.

The NRI was not published in a form compatible with the index for 2020; that year is marked NA for all countries. Annual scores are used directly for 2021–2025.

3. Global Internet Shutdowns (ISOC Pulse)

Source: Internet Society Pulse platform

Coverage: 2020–2025

This indicator is provided by the Internet Society's Pulse platform, which continuously monitors internet shutdown events globally. The data covers the number of shutdowns per country and the total duration in days. To account for the skewness and large range of values, a log transformation is applied ($\log(1 + \text{value})$), followed by min-max normalisation. An intermediate Impact Score is computed as the average of the two normalised components (frequency and duration). The final Shutdown Score applies a tiered approach: countries with zero shutdowns receive the maximum score of 100; countries with one or more shutdowns receive a base score of 60, reduced proportionally by their Impact Score ($\text{Score} = 60 - (60 \times \text{Impact Score})$). The United Kingdom is assigned a score of 100 for all years, reflecting a short-duration 2019 event that predates the index window and has no analytical relevance to current policy performance.

Rights and Freedoms

4. Freedom on the Net (FOTN)

Source: Freedom House

Coverage: 2020–2025 (~70 countries assessed annually)

Freedom on the Net is an annual assessment evaluating internet freedom globally, covering barriers to access, content restrictions, and violations of user rights. Scores range from 0 to 100, with higher values indicating greater internet freedom. FOTN scores are used directly. Approximately 70 countries are assessed each year; unassessed countries carry NA.

5. Freedom in the World Index (FitW)

Source: Freedom House

Coverage: 2020–2025 (all countries)

The Freedom in the World Index assesses the overall state of political rights and civil liberties in countries. It scores countries from 0 to 100, with higher scores denoting greater freedoms. A critical edition-offset rule applies: FitW Edition N assesses conditions during calendar year N–1. Accordingly, Edition 2021 is mapped to index year 2020, through to Edition 2025 mapped to index year 2024. Because no Edition 2026 had been published at the time of compilation, Edition 2025 is also used for index year 2025, meaning FitW values for 2024 and 2025 are identical.

6. Rule of Law Index (WJP)

Source: World Justice Project

Coverage: 2020–2025 (~140 countries assessed)

The World Justice Project Rule of Law Index measures how the rule of law is experienced in practice across eight factors, including constraints on government powers, absence of corruption, and protection of fundamental rights. The index scores countries from 0 to 1.00, with higher scores representing stronger rule of law. All values are multiplied by 100 to align with the Compass's 0–100 format. Countries not assessed by WJP are marked NA.

Responsibility and Sustainability

7. Global E-Waste Monitor

Source: Global E-Waste Monitor (ITU, in partnership with UN agencies)

Coverage: 2020–2023 (GEM 2020 publication); 2024–2025 (GEM 2024 publication)

The Global E-Waste Monitor reports on e-waste generation per capita globally, measuring kilograms of electronic waste generated per person annually. Higher values indicate higher consumption and potential environmental burden; the data has been normalised to a 0–100 scale in the Compass, where higher scores reflect better (lower) e-waste performance. Scores are assigned based on the publication date of each GEM edition rather than the underlying survey year: the GEM 2020 publication is used for index years 2020–2023, and the GEM 2024 publication is used for 2024 and 2025.

8. Global Index on Responsible AI (RespAI)

Source: Global Index on Responsible AI initiative

Coverage: 2024–2025 only; 2020–2023 = NA

The Global Index on Responsible AI evaluates countries' commitment to responsible AI development and deployment across governance, data practices, accountability, and inclusiveness. Scores are on a 0–100 scale. The index was not available in a form suitable for inclusion in historical editions prior to 2024; all earlier years are marked NA. The same edition is used for both 2024 and 2025.

9. Digital Trade Policies and Practices (DTI)

Source: Digital Trade Integration project (European University Institute)

Coverage: 2024–2025 only; 2020–2023 = NA

The Digital Trade Integration Index measures the openness and restrictiveness of digital trade policies, covering thousands of measures that either restrict or enable digital trade across countries. Enabling measures and restrictions are normalised to a 0–100 scale. The index was not available for historical editions prior to 2024; all earlier years are marked NA. The same edition is used for both 2024 and 2025.

Trust and Resilience

10. Global Cybersecurity Index (GCI)

Source: International Telecommunication Union (ITU)

Coverage: 2020–2023 (GCI v4, proxy carried forward); 2024–2025 (GCI 2024)

The GCI assesses countries' commitment to cybersecurity through legal, technical, organisational, capacity-building, and cooperation measures. Countries are ranked on a tier scale of 1–5, with lower scores indicating more advanced implementation. This data has been normalised to a 0–100 scale in the Compass. GCI v4 (published 2020) provides scores for index years 2020–2023; since no new edition was published until 2024, GCI v4 scores are carried forward as a proxy for 2021, 2022, and 2023. The GCI 2024 edition provides real scores for 2024 and 2025; since no 2025 edition existed at the time of compilation, the 2024 values are carried forward to 2025.

11. Overall Resilience Index (IRI)

Source: Internet Society Pulse platform

Coverage: 2020–2025 (annual)

Also from the Internet Society Pulse platform, the Resilience Index assesses the robustness of a country's internet infrastructure based on infrastructure quality, performance, security, and market readiness. Scored on a 0–100 scale, it provides a composite view of how resilient a country's internet ecosystem is against disruptions. Scores are used directly for all six index years.

12. Accountability Index (V-Dem)

Source: Varieties of Democracy (V-Dem) Project

Coverage: 2020–2025

The V-Dem Accountability Index (v2x_accountability) measures the extent to which citizens are able to hold their government accountable, assessing factors such as free and fair elections, transparency, and freedom of expression. The index is expressed on a scale of –2.0 to +2.0, with higher values indicating higher levels of accountability. This data has been converted by adding 2 and multiplying by 25 to achieve a 0–100 scale. Annual V-Dem dataset releases are used for index years 2020–2024, and V-Dem v16 is used for 2025.

Normalisation

Where normalisation is applied, the index uses a fixed min-max approach. Fixed reference points (anchored to observed global minima and maxima) are applied consistently across all years to ensure that a given score carries the same meaning in 2020 as in 2025. Year-specific min-max normalisation is not used, as it would create artificial year-to-year score changes driven by changes in the composition of the country set rather than genuine performance differences.

Data Availability Summary

The table below summarises data availability for each indicator across the index years. “Real” denotes year-specific data from the named source. “Proxy” denotes a carried-forward value. “NA” denotes no data available.

Indicator	2020	2021	2022	2023	2024	2025
IDI	Proxy	Proxy	Proxy	Real	Real	Real
NRI	NA	Real	Real	Real	Real	Real
Shutdowns	Real	Real	Real	Real	Real	Real
FOTN	Real	Real	Real	Real	Real	Real
FitW	Real	Real	Real	Real	Real	Real (=2024)
WJP	Real	Real	Real	Real	Real	Real
E-Waste	Real	Real	Real	Real	Real	Real (=2024)
RespAI	NA	NA	NA	NA	Real	Real (=2024)
DTI	NA	NA	NA	NA	Real	Real (=2024)
GCI	Real	Proxy	Proxy	Proxy	Real	Real (=2024)
IRI	Real	Real	Real	Real	Real	Real
V-Dem	Real	Real	Real	Real	Real	Real

Notes: "Real (=2024)" in the 2025 column indicates the same edition as 2024 is used, as no updated edition had been published at the time of compilation. "Proxy" indicates a carried-forward value from the most recent available edition. Entries marked NA have no available data and no applicable proxy.